century. Neither side looked up to the other or looked down at the other – at least until the nineteenth century when British interventions in China led to Chinese resentment and disdain towards India and Indians.

Perceptions in the Nineteenth and Early Twentieth Centuries

The commodities trade between India and China expanded and the nature of relations between the two changed during the colonial period. The Dutch linked India and China through the opium trade. They took opium from production centres in Patna and Malwa to China. From its original medicinal and aphrodisiacal uses, it became a recreational drug.[14] The opium trade would go on to have enormous consequences for India–China interactions over the next three hundred years or so. Under the British, Indian cotton and opium were increasingly traded for Chinese tea, silk, and sugar ('chini' or crystalline white sugar from China, as against the original dark sugar made in India). A financial system too sprang up, of credit bills, loans, and insurance. In addition, India–China economic interactions mediated by the British led to Indians working in China and the establishment of a Chinese community in India, around Calcutta mostly. As Chinese intellectuals reacted to the intrusions of the Western powers, they turned their attention to British rule in India, its antecedents and consequences. The interactions with Indians in China and the conclusions they drew about India were often negative.

Chinese Perceptions of India and Indians

Two sets of negative perceptions of India and Indians were formed as the two societies were interlinked by British rule. The first came out of Chinese encounters with Indians in China. The second grew out of Chinese intellectuals reflecting on India under British rule.